

# Abigail (Abby) Cassario

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## Current Position

*Graduate Student*, The Belief Systems Lab, Department of Psychology, Michigan State University

## Research Interests

Beliefs, Belief Systems, Ideology, Attitudes, Persuasion, Computational Social Science

## Teaching Interests

Political Behavior, Political Psychology, Intro to American Politics, Beliefs, Media, & Misinformation, Undergraduate Research Methods

## Education

- 2026 PH.D. in Social/Personality Psychology, Michigan State University (expected)
- 2021 M.A. in Political Science, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill
- 2019 B.A. in Political Science and Psychology, University of North Carolina at Asheville (Summa Cum Laude)

## Grants & Fellowships

- 2025 *Co-Investigator*, \$5,000 Institute for Humane Studies (IHS) Grant (with Mark Brandt, PI). *Project: Testing Side Effects of Polarization Reduction Interventions*
- 2025 PolNet–PaCSS 2025 Graduate Student Fellowship
- 2025 Summer Institute in Social and Personality Psychology (attendee)
- 2022–2023 MSU Graduate Merit Assistantship
- 2019–2024 UNC Chapel Hill Department of Political Science Thomas Uhlman Fellowship (declined, 2022–2024)
- 2019 UNC Chapel Hill Graduate Merit Assistantship

## Honors & Awards

- 2025 SPSP Student Publication Award for Best Graduate Student Publication in an SPSP Journal (for Cassario & Brandt, 2025)

## Research

### PEER REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

- 2025 Wetherell, G., Thompson, J. L., **Cassario, A. L.**, Brandt, M. J., Gnall, S., Rice, S., Solanki, P., Vallabha, S., & Carrillo, A. (in press). Do mismatches between individual and target group personality predict prejudice? *Collabra: Psychology*, *11*, 136887.
- 2025 **Cassario, A. L.**, Vallabha, S., Thompson, J. L., Carrillo, A., Solanki, P., Gnall, S. A., Wetherell, G., & Brandt, M. J. (2025). Registered report: Cognitive ability, but not cognitive reflection, predicts expressing greater political animosity and favouritism. *British Journal of Social Psychology*, *64*(2), e12814.
- 2025 **Cassario, A. L.**, & Brandt, M. J. (2025). Testing theories of threat, individual difference, and ideology: Little evidence of personality-based individual differences in ideological responses to threat. *Social Psychological and Personality Science*, *16*(6) 657-668‡
- ‡ Recipient of the SPSP Student Publication Award for Best Graduate Student Publication in an SPSP Journal, 2025.
- 2023 **Cassario, A. L.** (2023). Perceived vulnerability to infectious disease and perceived harmfulness are as predictive of citizen response to COVID-19 as partisanship. *Politics and the Life Sciences*, *42*(2), 277–290.
- 2019 Cox, K. S., Hanek, K. J., & **Cassario, A. L.** (2019). Redemption in a single low point story longitudinally predicts well-being: The incremental validity of life story elements. *Journal of Personality*, *87*(5), 1009–1024.

### EDITOR REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

- 2023 Brandt, M. J., & **Cassario, A. L.** (2023). Distinguishing between worldview conflict and shared alliances: Commentary on Pinsof, Sears, and Haselton. *Psychological Inquiry*, *34*(3), 168–174.

### ACCEPTED STAGE 1 REGISTERED REPORTS

- 2023 Thompson, J. L., **Cassario, A. L.**, Rice, S., Gnall, S. A., Carrillo, A., Solanki, P., Vallabha, S., Brandt, M. J., & Wetherell, G. (2023). Registered report: Stress testing predictive models of ideological prejudice. *PLOS ONE*.

## UNDER REVIEW

- 2025 Triki, A.<sup>†</sup>, **Cassario, A. L.**, & Brandt, M. J. (Manuscript in preparation, target: *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*). There is more evidence for ideological symmetry than asymmetry in party cue effects across a representative sample of issues.

## SELECTED CURRENT PROJECTS

- 2025 **Cassario, A. L.**, Triki, A.<sup>†</sup>, & Brandt, M. J. (Manuscript in preparation, target: *Political Behavior*). Threat exposure does not predict increased conservatism in three large experiments: Evidence from the U.S.

<sup>†</sup>Denotes mentored undergraduate student

- 2025 **Cassario, A. L.**, Vallabha, S., & Brandt, M. J. (Manuscript in preparation, target: *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*). Central attitudes in political belief systems are more resistant to change but are not necessarily less responsive to persuasive interventions.

- 2025 **Cassario, A. L.**, & Brandt, M. J. (Data collection complete, target: *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*). Conviction cascades: Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties.

- 2025 Brandt, M. J., & **Cassario, A. L.** (Data collection complete). Within-person fluctuations in daily stress do not predict political prejudice or engagement, but higher between-person stress does: Evidence from an EMA study.

- 2025 **Cassario, A. L.** (Data collection ongoing). Exploring the effects of anticipated, actual, and perceived downward mobility on political attitudes.

## Invited Talks

- 2025 Cassario, A. L. (2025, Spring). Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties. Invited talk at the Interdisciplinary Consortium on Moral Decision Making, Pennsylvania State University, State College, PA.

- 2025 Cassario, A. L. (2025, Spring). Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties. Invited talk at the Inequality Working Group Meeting (virtual).

## Conference Symposia (Organized)

- 2026 **Cassario, A. L.** (Chair). *Moral Minds in Polarized Times*. Symposium accepted for presentation at the Society for Personality and Social Psychology (SPSP) Annual Convention, Chicago, IL. February 2026.

*Includes my talk: Conviction Cascades: Moral Conviction Transmits Through Belief System Ties.*

## Selected Conference Presentations

- 2025      **Cassario, A. L. & Brandt, M. J.** *Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties*. Poster presented at *MIT Directions of Polarization, Norms, and Trust in Societies*, Cambridge, MA, December 2025.
- 2025      **Cassario, A. L.** *Conviction cascades: Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties*. Talk presented at the *International Society of Political Psychology (ISPP) Annual Meeting*, Prague, Czech Republic, July 2025.
- 2024      **Cassario, A. L. & Brandt, M. J.** *Testing theories of threat, individual difference, and ideology: Little evidence of personality-based individual differences in ideological responses to threat*. Poster presented at the *Society for Personality and Social Psychology (SPSP) Annual Convention*, San Diego, CA, February 2024.
- 2022      **Cassario, A. L.** *Not all motivated reasoning is partisan: Personality and harm perceptions limit the influence of partisanship in shaping citizens' perceptions of COVID-19*. Paper presented at the *Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Annual Meeting*, Chicago, IL, April 2022.

## Teaching Experience

Introduction to Social Psychology (MSU, instructor of record)  
Introduction to Personality Psychology (MSU, TA, grader)  
Psychology of Women (MSU, TA, grader)  
Introduction to R Programming and Statistics (MSU, TA, section instructor; UNC, TA, grader)  
Introduction to American Politics (UNC, TA, section instructor)  
Race, Innocence and the Death Penalty (UNC, TA, section instructor)

## Professional Service

- 2023–2024      Graduate Student Advisory Committee (GSAC), Social/Personality Area Representative, Michigan State University Department of Psychology

### Ad-hoc Reviewer

*Legislative Studies Quarterly*  
*Political Behavior*  
*American Journal of Political Science*  
*Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*  
*British Journal of Social Psychology*  
*Politics and the Life Sciences*  
*Psychological Science*  
*Social Psychological and Personality Science*

*Journal of Personality*  
*Analysis of Social Issues and Public Policy*

## Computer Skills

R (Advanced)  
Qualtrics (Advanced)  
SAS (Intermediate)  
SPSS (Intermediate)  
MATLAB (Beginner)  
Github (Beginner)  
Python (Beginner)  
L<sup>A</sup>T<sub>E</sub>X

## References

Mark Brandt, Associate Professor of Psychology, Michigan State University, [brandt15@msu.edu](mailto:brandt15@msu.edu)  
Jennifer Wolak, Professor of Political Science, Michigan State University, [wolakjen@msu.edu](mailto:wolakjen@msu.edu)  
Tedmond Schwaba, Assistant Professor of Psychology, Michigan State University, [schwabat@msu.edu](mailto:schwabat@msu.edu)  
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